

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

*Illuminated: A Cinematic Journey to Deeper Spirituality
Remembering the Future*

February 23rd, 2025



Remember (1924) by Nicholas Roerich

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Organ Prelude Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, Organist-in- Residence

Improvisation on HOUGHTON and BROTHER JAMES' AIR

Pergolesi Paraphrases: *Stabat Mater* Part 1

Solace (Scott Joplin)

Fugue in G minor, BWV 542/2 (Johann Sebastian Bach)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

When hope invites us to journey,
elusive, beckoning onward
but never in our grasp:
*God of wisdom and promise,
give us courage to travel on.*

When dreams glimmer in the distance,
fading, clouded, and hidden
or shining with new brightness:
*God of wisdom and promise,
give us courage to travel on.*

When established patterns collapse
into the uncertainty of the unknown
and security dissolves into a memory:
*God of wisdom and promise,
give us courage to travel on.*

When the illusion of success
threatens to divert us
and silence our souls' yearning:
*God of wisdom and promise,
give us courage to travel on.*

When we think our journey has ended
in the star-lit glow, only to find
the end is a new beginning:
*God of wisdom and promise,
give us courage to travel on.* [JBerry/ssb]

On this eighth Sunday of Epiphany,
we gather to remember the future,
knowing that we follow the path
of Jesus, a path we travel together.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!

Please stand now in body or in spirit for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering.**

Colorful Creator

HOUGHTON

Colorful Creator, God of mystery,
Thank you for the artist teaching us to see
Glimpses of the meaning of the commonplace,
Vision of the holy in each human face.

Harmony of ages, God of list'ning ear,
Thank you for composers tuning us to hear
Echoes of the Gospel in the songs we sing,
Sounds of love and longing from the deepest spring.

Author of our journey, God of near and far,
Praise for tale and drama telling who we are,
Stripping to the essence struggles of our day,
Times of change and conflict when we choose our way.

God of truth and beauty, Poet of the Word,
May we be creators by the Spirit stirred,
Open to your presence in our joy and strife,
Vessels of the holy coursing through our life.

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Michael Lehman

Eternal One,
we gather to renew our confidence
in a more illuminated future,
as we enter your kin-dom,
here and now,
as a foretaste of what is to come.

We give ourselves to this emerging future,
knowing that our choices,
no matter how small,
resonate across every strand of this cosmic web.

We know, O God, that we are not alone as future-forgers:
In our fear
that keeps us looking back over our shoulder,
the Spirit is with us.

*In our passion
to create a holy future,
the Spirit is with us.*

In our resolve to overcome
all that keeps us from our ideals,
the Spirit is with us.

*Lift us up, abiding Spirit,
above all obstacles,
and grant us a glimpse
of what is possible
when hearts and minds
discover that you inhabit our fears, our hopes,
and our commitments, and love us through them all.*

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

***Introit**

ADOLPHUS HAILSTORK

"I Sent My Soul Into The Invisible" from Seven Songs of the Rubaiyat
Laude

***The Lord's Prayer**

*Our [God], who art in heaven,
hallowed be thy Name,
thy kingdom come, thy will be done,
on earth as it is in heaven.
Give us this day our daily bread,
and forgive us our debts,
as we forgive our debtors.
And lead us not into temptation,
but deliver us from evil.
For thine is the kingdom,
and the power, and the glory,
forever.
Amen.*

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

When the way is convoluted
and confusing,
when the choice is not clear
and uncertainty presses close,
may we be the ones through whom

God's love and longing speak,
and in speaking, may we show a way
to make real the reign of God
in this, our time and place.

[adapt/JanRichardson]

This morning, may the Peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow.

Please be seated

Reading from Our Religious Tradition
from the Gospel of Luke

The Pharisees asked Jesus when the reign of God would come. Jesus replied, "The reign of God doesn't come in a visible way. You can't say, 'See, here it is!' or 'There it is!' No—look: the reign of God is already in your midst."

This is the Gospel of Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Holy One,
all around us and all within us is gift.
You are ever on the move,
ever calling us into the future –
creative, playful,
dazzlingly loving God.

This morning,
may we find joy within ourselves,
wisdom in our flaws,
and amazement and gratitude
in this ongoing process
of becoming who we are.

Help us to realize, Holy One,
we need not be that which we cannot be -
help us to leave behind those caricatures of
what others said we should be...
and help us to embrace the marvelous person
you created us to be.

Let us boldly and humbly embrace the life
we are co-creating with you
and with each other.

O God, in these moments,
let this wonder and your ever expanding love for us
sink deep into our hearts and minds,
healing the pain of the past,
even as we are becoming part of this uncertain present...
and as we live together, and with you,
let us claim for all our siblings - the amazing future we will cocreate.
Amen and Amen!

Meditation Anthem

"I Got It Bad, And That Ain't Good"
Marc Doten, *Piano*

DUKE ELLINGTON

Sermon

Remembering the Future

Rev. Lehman

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Lehman & Rev. Tanaka Pack

Gathered here to share bread and cup
in memory of the Christ,
together, we give our 'Amen'
to the belief
that we live in love
we live in God and God lives and loves in us.

This morning, we break this bread:
bread that invites us to grasp what the eye
cannot see:
God with us in the journey of life;
God with us in the ordinary
and the everyday;
God with us in the hard times
and the good times;
God within us,
in our living and loving.

As we eat this bread, let us give our 'Amen'
to God living and loving fully in us.

We also, pour this cup,
that reminds us of the promises to love,
of that love shared generously,
of Jesus who loved so totally,
and of our call to love as courageously
as they loved.

As we drink this cup,
may it help us to allow the spirit of
the Christ to motivate all we do,

so that what we profess to have seen in their life
and heard in their teaching
might be evident in our living and loving.

Prayer of Blessing

Rev. Tanaka Pack

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Communion Music

“neither this world nor the next”
Dr. Fahad Siadat

FAHAD SIADAT

Invitation to Generosity

Rev. Tanaka Pack

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how it's given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also be available at the exits when the service ends with baskets to collect gifts.

Offertory

“How Lovely Is Thy Dwelling Place” from *A German Requiem*
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, Assistant Director

JOHANNES BRAHMS

***Doxology**

From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

***Prayer of Offering**

Holy God, we are your people, created in your image.
In our diversity, we have strength;
in our shared humanity, a common hope,
a vision of life unbound by time.

We have come together
to recommit ourselves to your work.
Shake us out of our complacency,
rock our comfortable certainties,
and challenge us to recognize the face of the Christ
in the eyes of everyone we meet.

May our hearts be open to the challenge
of your call to true freedom,
our minds and hands ready
to grasp the opportunity for change.

Inspire us with your message,
open us to the joy of your word,
and guide us as we prepare
to answer your call to open our doors
even wider in this time -
and in this place, we call home.

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Lehman

So may we know
the hope
that is not just
for someday
but for this day—
here, now,
in this moment
that opens to us:

*hope not made
of wishes
but of substance,*

hope made of sinew
and muscle
and bone,

*hope that has breath
and a beating heart,*

hope that will not
keep quiet
and be polite,

*hope that knows
how to holler
when it is called for,*

hope that knows
how to sing
when there seems
little cause,

*hope that raises us
from death to life—
not someday
but this day,
every day,
again and
again and
again!*

Choral Response

“We Shall Walk Through The Valley”
Cathedral Choir

UNDINE SMITH MOORE

***Hymn for the Journey**

The Sun Is on the Sea and Shore

BROTHER JAMES' AIR

The sun is on the sea and shore, a new day has begun
With morning hymns we will adore the blessed Three-in-One;
And we shall praise you ever more, until the day is done.

Your love is ever in our view, like shining stars by night
Your gifts are every morning new, Oh God of love and light;
Your mercy, like the heavens blue, fills our dazzled sight

We do not know what grief and care each coming day may bring;
The heart shall find some gladness there that trusts you in each thing;
The life that serves you everywhere will never cease to sing.

Please be seated for the Postlude

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Amen (Giovanni Battista Pergolesi) and Improvisation

Inside The Music

“Our celebration of Black History Month this week includes three contemporaries whose musical voices were quite different. Undine Smith Moore and Duke Ellington were only separated in age by five years. Smith Moore, known as “The Dean of Black Women Composers,” was trained as a classical pianist. Her collegiate professorships led her to become a groundbreaking educator. Her compositional work centered on the voice in solo and choral contexts. Many of her compositions, like “We Shall Walk Through The Valley,” are settings of Negro Spirituals. This particular setting represents American choral music of the mid 20th century, with its sensitivity to line, lush harmony, and timbral unity. Ellington’s reputation as a jazz composer and band leader is widely known. Fewer people know that he also composed for choirs. Today, though, we have the treat of hearing one of his hits played by Marc Doten. Marc has the most seniority on the artistic team at FCCLA, but you don’t normally see him, because he runs sound for us. He is also an accomplished musician, as you will hear. Nat King Cole made “I’ve Got It Bad, and That Ain’t Good” a mega hit in the 1950s. The lyrics reflect on the perceived reality of the singer, who suffers under the illusion that the person (s)he loves doesn’t feel the same. The emotionally lopsided relationship leaves the singer feeling unsettled, but not unhappy. I found an alignment between this version of uneasiness and the theme for the week. Our struggle to perceive life, let alone afterlife, leaves us uneasy, but rarely unhappy, I’ve found. The music, typical of Ellington’s output, is replete with energizing melodic leaps, internal counterpoint, sweet and smooth harmonies, and a general longing that flows from his particular ear toward the human condition. As an instrumental solo, all of that same energy comes through, perhaps even a little more condensed than

when words are there to distract us. When I write music, one of the things I listen for is whether the music would communicate without the lyrics present. Ellington's music always does. Adolphus Hailstork is 40 years their junior, and benefited from their output. His music has a muscular, frontal quality to it that asks a lot out of the singer and listener alike. He gives much more in return for the effort. The fullness of his musical language is coupled with intuitive voice leading and dramatic intent such that difficult music doesn't sound or feel difficult. It simply communicates. The last short movement of "Seven Songs of the Rubaiyat" center on today's theme. One particular fascinating musical moment comes as it starts. The text, "my soul...answered 'I myself am Heaven and Hell'" is evocative enough. After a transition from A minor, Hailstork spends the movement oscillating between D major and Eb minor. The two have a common note in F# / Gb, and he cleverly combines them in different ways across the piece to create other harmonies as well. On this last line, D major becomes the only harmony for "I myself am Heaven" and Eb minor for "Hell," as if a moment of truth has arrived. In the next phrase, however, Heaven becomes a C half diminished 7th chord, a more intense elaboration of Eb minor, and a reference to the opening of the movement where C is prominent. As we are just getting used to the cognitive dissonance, we get to "Hell" again, this time with both chords equally represented. Eb minor sounds in the tenor and bass, and D major in the treble voices. The complexity of the thought rings its ambiguities into the room, sounding its new, more complicated truth. As the air clears, the two chords resolve in either direction to D minor 9 with the words "Come fill the cup!" The piece ends triumphantly, excitedly, and with reflection on the human existence as one of experience. To experience life, Hailstork invites us to consider, we must first accept ourselves as full beings within it. Once we internalize that the afterlife concepts of Heaven and Hell are actually manifest in us now, today, as we are, we can welcome life in its abundance." ~ Dr. David Harris